

Migrant removals unlawful, judge rules

President exceeded his authority under wartime act because no ‘invasion’

BY MARIA SACCHETTI AND MARIANNE LEVINE

A Trump-appointed federal judge ruled Thursday that the president exceeded his authority by invoking the Alien Enemies Act to summarily deport Venezuelan migrants, dealing a blow to the administration’s deportation efforts and permanently barring such removals in South Texas.

In a 36-page ruling, U.S. District Judge Fernando Rodriguez Jr. in Brownsville, Texas, rejected President Donald Trump’s declarations that the United States was being invaded by a Venezuelan gang to justify using a centuries-old act to deport migrants without a hearing. He said the president’s action “exceeds the scope of the statute.”

Trump signed a proclamation invoking the act in March to summarily deport more than 130 immigrants to a megaprison in El Salvador, many from South Texas, and his officials have vowed to send more. But Rodriguez said the proclamation lacked evidence of an invasion and was therefore unlawful.

Lawyers for the plaintiffs say this is the first decision permanently rejecting the administration’s legal justifications for using the act. The ruling applies only to migrants detained in southeast-

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Florida: Agents arrest over 1,100 in sweep targeting immigrants. A3

Cuts target grants for counseling at schools

Mental health experts reject claim that funds promoted racial quotas

BY BEN BRASCH

The Education Department this week began cutting about \$1 billion in mental-health-related grants created in response to mass school shootings, claiming that schools that want to diversify their pool of psychologists are misusing the funds.

School psychology professionals across the country are scrambling to figure out how to move forward after being told funding for their multiyear programs will expire at the end of December if they don’t decide to appeal. The two grants affected received an additional \$1 billion after President Joe Biden signed a sweeping bipartisan gun-control bill into law in 2022, a month after the mass shooting at Robb Elementary School in Uvalde, Texas.

The cuts that started Tuesday are in line with President Donald Trump’s executive order that seeks to eliminate programs that foster diversity, equity and inclusion in schools. Last month the administration canceled grants funding gun-violence prevention programs and crime-victim advo-

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ANDREW HARNIK/GETTY IMAGES

Michael Waltz at the White House on Thursday. After his removal as national security adviser, he will be nominated for U.N. ambassador.

Musk wants Congress to finish what DOGE started

BY CAT ZAKRZEWSKI, MATT VISER, EMILY DAVIES AND ELIZABETH DWOSKIN

Elon Musk arrived at the White House prepared to take a chain saw to the federal government, promising to slash \$2 trillion in spending.

A little more than 100 days later, the world’s richest man is retreating from Washington far short of that goal after an often painful education in the mechanics of the U.S. government.

As Musk prepares to return to his private companies in coming weeks, he and his allies are increasingly pressing for Congress to take up the mantle of their government cost-cutting. But that effort faces an uncertain future in a largely frozen Congress that has passed few bills

As billionaire steps back, his cost-cutting initiative faces uncertain future

since President Donald Trump took office in January.

In a meeting with reporters Wednesday, Musk boasted about the U.S. DOGE Service’s success but appeared sober about its future. He estimated the project will save \$160 billion in fiscal year 2026, but that tally lacks many specific details. Musk said those savings are “pretty good,” even though it was only a fraction of his initial promise, which he said would take a long road to reach.

“How much pain is the Cabinet and this Congress willing to

take?” he said to reporters in the Roosevelt Room. “Because it can be done, but it requires dealing with a lot of complaints.”

Musk said he is planning to meet in the next week with lawmakers in the DOGE caucuses from the House and Senate, underscoring how his attention has, in part, shifted to finding ways to codify the many cuts and changes he has tried to make to the federal bureaucracy.

David Sacks, a close friend of Musk and the White House’s AI and crypto czar, said it is now up to Washington politicians to act on Musk’s findings.

“At the end of the day, in order to capture the savings here, we do need those appropriations eliminated from the budget,” Sacks said on an episode of the “All In” podcast that aired Saturday. “It’s not up to DOGE to do

that. It’s up to these old bulls in Congress who control the appropriations process.”

States, labor unions, local governments and nonprofit organizations have launched a legal barrage against many of the Trump administration’s efforts to cut the scale and size of the federal workforce, arguing that Congress needs to approve these actions.

DOGE’s strategy has also always involved seeking favorable decisions in the courts that could allow the agency to have lasting influence, while bypassing Congress’s role in setting federal

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Foreign aid cuts: Three months later, the toll begins to sink in. A13

DOGE days wind down: Elon Musk reflects on White House time. A16

Papacy may be poised to return to Italian hands

Italy ruled the Catholic Church for centuries, but not since 1978. Now, some are daring to dream.



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

Cardinals at the funeral Mass of Pope Francis last month in Vatican City. Italy has more cardinals talked about as top contenders for pope than any other country. The papal enclave starts next week.

BY ANTHONY FAIOLA, STEFANO PITRELLI AND MICHELLE BOORSTEIN

ROME — Ahead of the 2013 conclave to replace Pope Benedict XVI, Cardinal Angelo Scola of Milan was tipped to restore the papal hat to an Italian. Italians got the next best thing in Pope Francis — the Argentine son of Italian immigrants. But many here wondered whether one of their own would ever again sit on the throne of St. Peter.

Now some Italians are daring to dream again.

The papal conclave that begins Wednesday remains unpredictable, with the largest and most diverse group of cardinals in church history set to elect the next leader of 1.4 billion Catholics. As the princes of the church prepare to shutter themselves in the Sistine Chapel, Italy has more cardinals talked about as top contenders than any other country, boosting the chances of a nation that birthed roughly 80 percent of the 266 popes — though none since 1978.

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National security adviser ousted

RUBIO TO FILL ROLE ON INTERIM BASIS

Waltz’s decision-making, Signal use drew criticism

This article is by John Hudson, Karen DeYoung, Adam Taylor, Abigail Hauslohner and Michael Birnbaum

President Donald Trump ordered the biggest personnel shake-up of his new administration on Thursday, replacing his national security adviser, Michael Waltz, with Secretary of State Marco Rubio, who will carry out the job on an interim basis while also serving as the nation’s top diplomat. Trump said he is nominating Waltz as U.N. ambassador.

The decision reflects Trump’s disappointment with Waltz over his inadvertent inclusion of a journalist on a group chat about military operations in Yemen, and broader frustration over Waltz’s appointment of staffers viewed as disloyal to the president.

But in choosing to nominate him as U.N. ambassador, a job that requires Senate approval, Trump has set the stage for a contentious confirmation process that will allow Democrats to grill Waltz over the opening months of Trump presidency’s and compel sworn testimony on sensitive matters including immigration, tariff policy,

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Campaign pledge: Trump ran on buoying riches, as volatility rises. A4

Biden-era aide goes all in on Hegseth

Marine’s rise draws bipartisan notice amid security lapses, turnover

BY MISSY RYAN AND DAN LAMOTHE

Pete Hegseth’s 100-day tenure as defense secretary has brought an unceremonious end to the careers of numerous top military officers — but it has also created unexpected avenues for advancement, including for one Marine who has thrown his lot in with the controversial Pentagon chief.

Biden-era officials say they were flabbergasted when Ricky Buria, a respected officer who worked closely with Defense Secretary Lloyd Austin, abruptly set aside a promising future in uniform to retire from the military and assume a political position as a senior adviser to Hegseth, whose security lapses and anti-diversity agenda have fueled widespread calls from Democrats, and at least one Republican, to resign.

The change in course by Buria, who had been seen as a rising star in the Marine Corps, underscores the different ways in which Hegseth’s disruptive approach is impacting the military ranks — such as the summary ouster of at least

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IN THE NEWS

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Virginia controversy mounts A top aide to Gov. Glenn Youngkin offered to step down after an audio clip added fuel to a dispute with a GOP nominee over “extortion” claims. B1

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STYLE The allegations against Sean “Diddy” Combs twist a familiar playbook for powerful men in the music industry. C1

WEEKEND Midnight craving? Don’t settle for slimy pizza. These 15 joints offer elevated fare as the rest of the city sleeps.

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